

Diagnostic of Theoretical Framing: “The Foreign Policy Impact of Trade-Based Status Gains: Evidence from Brazil”

1. Diagnostic of the Research Question

Current question

“We investigate what are the political payoffs of an increase in status?” (Section 1, line 75)

A secondary formulation also appears: > “Should a one-off rank reversal, rather than gradual accumulation of trade, have lasting foreign-policy effects?” (Section 1, line 54)

Problem identified

The first formulation is too broad (“political payoffs of an increase in status” could refer to anything—military, economic, diplomatic). The second formulation is sharper but is phrased rhetorically, not as a theoretical question. More critically, both formulations oscillate between the general and the particular: by line 75, the question has already been anchored in the Brazilian case (“We investigate what are the political payoffs of an increase in status?... we exploit a clear ‘rank effect’: in 2009 China overtook the United States as Brazil’s top trading partner”). The theoretical question and the empirical case are fused rather than sequenced.

The paper’s actual theoretical proposition is more specific than either formulation suggests: it is about **discrete rank reversals in trade hierarchies** producing **disproportionate foreign policy alignment**, mediated by **salience**. This is not about “status” in general—it is about a specific type of status change (ordinal, in trade), operating through a specific channel (salience/attention), producing a specific outcome (UNGA voting alignment).

Suggested reformulation

“Do discrete rank reversals in trade hierarchies—moments when a rising power displaces an established partner as a country’s top trading partner—produce disproportionate shifts in foreign policy alignment, beyond what gradual trade accumulation would predict?”

Justification

This reformulation: (a) specifies the type of status change (rank reversal in trade, not status in general); (b) identifies the key contrast (discrete vs. gradual); (c) makes no reference to Brazil, China, or 2009—the case enters later as the testing ground; (d) is falsifiable—if the effect is proportional to trade volume with no discontinuity at the rank-change moment, the hypothesis fails.

2. Epistemic positioning: generate or test theory?

Diagnosis of current state

The paper oscillates explicitly. Line 375 states: “**The Brazilian case generates the theory**”, but line 105 says: “**Brazil’s case provides the ideal setting to test our theory.**” These are contradictory epistemic claims. The structure of the paper reflects this ambiguity: the theory section (§2) builds the argument *from* the

case, but the empirical sections present results as if they constitute a rigorous *test*. The cross-country analysis (§7) is introduced as external validity, which presupposes the Brazilian analysis is the primary test—but if Brazil generates the theory, it cannot simultaneously test it.

Recommendation: Hybrid structured

Detailed justification

1. **Theoretical maturity of the field:** There is no prior formalized theory about the *consequences* of status gains in IR. The status literature (Renshon 2017; Ward 2017; Dafoe et al. 2014) focuses almost exclusively on status *deficits* and *conflict*. There is no theory predicting that a state gaining trade-rank status would receive diplomatic concessions. The rank-effects literature exists in domestic politics (Anagol & Fujiwara 2016; Fujiwara & Sanz 2020) but has never been extended to international politics. **This favors theory generation:** the paper is proposing something genuinely new, not testing an existing prediction.
2. **Strength of the empirical design:** The SDiD for Brazil is credible for a single-unit design—covariates, time weights, temporal placebos. But N=1 designs are inherently limited as “tests” because they cannot rule out case-specific confounders (Lula presidency, 2008 crisis). The cross-country DiD on 13 countries is a stronger test design: larger N, staggered treatment, never-treated controls. **This favors a hybrid:** SDiD for Brazil generates; cross-country DiD tests.
3. **Properties of the case:** Brazil is a *most-likely* case for the theory: the US was Brazil’s top trade partner for ~80 years, making the displacement maximally salient; Brazil has a free press (media channel can operate); Brazil is a regional power, not a small state (rules out coercion). Most-likely cases are well-suited for **theory generation with confirmatory value:** if the effect doesn’t appear here, it’s unlikely to appear anywhere.
4. **Structure of the evidence:** The paper already has the structure for a hybrid: (a) Brazilian SDiD + media analysis = theory generation and suggestive mechanism evidence; (b) cross-country DiD = test of a core prediction (that the effect generalizes when China displaces the *hegemon*). **This structure is defensible** if explicitly labeled.
5. **Marginal contribution:** The contribution is clearly greater as a **new framework** than as a test of existing theory—because there is no existing theory to test. The paper opens a research agenda (rank effects in international politics) rather than confirming/refuting a known proposition.

Implications for the paper’s structure

- **Language of claims:** The Brazilian analysis should use exploratory language (“we find evidence consistent with...”, “the Brazilian case reveals...”). The cross-country analysis can use confirmatory language (“this test supports the prediction that...”).
- **Section structure:** The theory section should present the general argument *before* mentioning Brazil. Brazil enters as “a case particularly suited to explore this proposition because...” The cross-country section should be framed as “testing a core prediction of the theory.”
- **Role of media evidence:** Under a hybrid framing, the media analysis is **illustrative process-tracing**—it shows *how* the mechanism might operate in this case, not that it *does* operate in general. This is a lower but more honest bar.
- **Scope of the conclusion:** Should emphasize agenda-opening over confirmation. “We have proposed and found initial support for...” rather than “we have shown that...”

3. Reconstructed Theoretical Argument

3a. Key concepts that need refinement

Concept	Current definition	Problem	Suggested definition	Source
Status	“the ranking or relative standing of a state” (line 101, citing MacDonald & Parent 2021)	Conflates continuous measure (relative standing) with ordinal (rank). The paper acknowledges this ambiguity but doesn’t resolve it definitively in the definition.	“Status-as-rank: the ordinal position of a state in a hierarchy relevant to a specific domain (here, trade). Distinct from status-as-standing (continuous relative capability).”	MacDonald & Parent (2021); Renshon (2017)
Salience	Used throughout but never formally defined. Sometimes means “media attention” (§5.1), sometimes “cognitive accessibility” (§2), sometimes “political focal point” (§2).	Three distinct concepts under one label. Media salience ≠ cognitive salience ≠ political salience.	Decompose into: (a) <i>cognitive salience</i> : ease of processing (coarse categorization); (b) <i>media salience</i> : volume and framing of coverage; (c) <i>political salience</i> : entry into policymakers’ agenda. Specify which is being invoked at each point.	Soroka (2003); Graeber et al. (2025); Edwards & Wood (1999)

Concept	Current definition	Problem	Suggested definition	Source
Rank reversal	“China overtook the United States as Brazil’s top trading partner” (line 50)	Clear empirically, but not theorized as a general concept. What counts as a rank reversal? Only #1 vs #2? Or also #2 vs #3? The placebos in 2003/2005 (when China moved from #3 to #2) finding null effects implicitly answer this, but it should be theorized.	“A rank reversal occurs when an emerging power displaces an established partner at the top of a country’s trade hierarchy. We theorize that only the #1 position carries sufficient symbolic weight to trigger the salience mechanism.”	Anagol & Fujiwara (2016); Fujiwara & Sanz (2020)
Foreign policy alignment	Absolute distance in UNGA ideal points (Bailey et al. 2017)	Well-defined operationally. However, the paper doesn’t discuss <i>why</i> UNGA voting should capture trade-related alignment, given that UNGA resolutions primarily address political/humanitarian issues, not trade.	Add explicit discussion: UNGA ideal points capture <i>general</i> state preferences, not trade-specific preferences. The claim is that rank reversal shifts <i>overall</i> diplomatic posture, not just trade policy. This is actually a stronger claim and should be noted.	Bailey et al. (2017); Struver (2016)

3b. Causal mechanism

Channel as proposed by the paper: The paper proposes “rank-salience” as a single mechanism, but actually describes at least three distinct channels under this label: 1. *Cognitive*: Decision-makers use coarse categories; the rank reversal enters their “consideration set” (Mintz 2004; Graeber et al. 2025; Enke 2024) 2. *Media*: The rank reversal is “newsworthy,” generating disproportionate coverage that shifts public/elite attention (Edwards & Wood 1999) 3. *Coordination*: The rank reversal serves as a focal point for business lobbies and bureaucrats to coordinate pressure (implied, citing Granzier et al. 2023 on bandwagon effects)

These are presented as if they were the same thing. They are not.

Channels identified in the literature (from Phase 2):

- **Channel 1: Coarse categorization (cognitive)**
 - Logic: Decision-makers process “China is now #1 partner” more easily than “China’s trade share increased from 11.2% to 13.7%.” The discrete category triggers attention and policy response.
 - Empirical evidence: Strong in behavioral economics (Graeber et al. 2025; Enke 2020) and domestic politics (Anagol & Fujiwara 2016; Fujiwara & Sanz 2020). No direct evidence in international politics.
 - Relevance: **High** — this is the paper’s core micro-foundation.
 - Distinguishable? Only testable with experimental or survey data on policymakers. Not distinguishable in the paper’s observational design.
- **Channel 2: Media agenda-setting**
 - Logic: Media reports the milestone → increased public/elite attention to China → pressure for policy change.
 - Empirical evidence: Strong for conflict/security topics (Soroka 2003; Baum & Potter 2008, 2015). No direct evidence that media coverage of *trade milestones* causes foreign policy shifts.
 - Relevance: **High** — this is the channel the paper provides most evidence for (NLP analysis).
 - Distinguishable? Partially. The paper shows media coverage increased, but cannot show it *preceded* or *caused* the policy shift (rather than co-occurring with it).
- **Channel 3: Political coordination / focal point**
 - Logic: The rank reversal serves as a Schelling focal point, enabling business lobbies, bureaucrats, and diplomats to coordinate demands for policy change.
 - Empirical evidence: Anagol & Fujiwara (2016) argue that the runner-up effect in elections operates more through *strategic coordination* than individual cognitive biases. No direct evidence in international contexts.
 - Relevance: **Medium** — theoretically plausible but untested in the paper.
 - Distinguishable? Yes, in principle. This channel predicts stronger effects in countries with organized business lobbies linked to China trade. The paper doesn’t test this.
- **Channel 4: Interest redefinition (gradual)**
 - Logic: Growing trade creates vested economic interests that lobby for alignment.
 - Empirical evidence: Flores-Macias & Kreps (2013); Kastner & Pearson (2021); Wang et al. (2023).
 - Relevance: **High as alternative explanation** — this is the “smooth” mechanism the paper argues against.
 - Distinguishable? Yes — it predicts effects proportional to trade *level*, not discrete effects at rank change. The temporal placebos partially distinguish this.
- **Channel 5: Structural power / dual hegemony**
 - Logic: China’s rise as a global power gravitationally attracts alignment, independent of specific trade milestones.

- Empirical evidence: Schenoni & Leiva (2021); Urdinez et al. (2016); Urdinez (2024).
- Relevance: **High as alternative explanation** — predicts gradual trend, not discontinuity.
- Distinguishable? Partially — the SDiD controls for power gap and time trends, but cannot fully separate “rank effect” from “power transition threshold.”

- **Channel 6: Paradoxical balancing effect**

- Logic: Increased trade with China may cause *some* states to align more with the *US* as a balancing response.
- Empirical evidence: Carmody, Dasandi & Mikhaylov (2020) find that more trade with China leads *African* states to align more with the US in UNGA (except on human rights votes).
- Relevance: **Medium-high** — this is a potentially devastating counterexample. If the mechanism is trade → alignment with the trade partner, why does it work in opposite directions for Brazil and Africa?
- Distinguishable? The rank-reversal theory could actually *explain* this paradox: in Africa, China didn’t necessarily displace the *hegemon* as #1 partner. The symbolic weight is lower. This would strengthen the paper’s argument but needs to be discussed.

Critical assessment: - The paper **conflates** channels 1-3 under “salience.” They should be presented as complementary but distinct. - The design **cannot distinguish** channels 1, 2, and 3 from each other. The SDiD captures the total effect. The media analysis provides suggestive evidence for channel 2 specifically, but not causal evidence. - The design **can distinguish** the combined rank-salience effect (channels 1-3) from the gradual mechanisms (channels 4-5) through temporal placebos. - Channel 6 (paradoxical balancing) is **absent from the paper** and needs to be discussed as an alternative prediction.

Suggested restructuring of the mechanism:

Present the theory section as follows: 1. **The gradualist consensus:** Existing mechanisms (coercion, interests, soft power, structural power) all assume influence scales smoothly with trade volume. [Existing material, reorganized] 2. **Why rank reversals matter:** Argue that discrete changes in ordinal position produce disproportionate responses. Ground in rank-effects literature (Anagol & Fujiwara 2016; Fujiwara & Sanz 2020) and coarse categorization (Graeber et al. 2025). This is the *claim*. 3. **Three complementary channels of rank-salience:** (a) Cognitive — coarse categorization; (b) Media — agenda-setting amplification; (c) Political — coordination via focal point. Be explicit that the empirical design captures the *total* effect across all channels, while the media analysis provides suggestive evidence for channel (b) specifically. 4. **Scope conditions and hypotheses** (see §4-5 below).

3c. Connection mechanism → estimand

- The SDiD estimand captures the **total effect** of the rank reversal on UNGA distance—across all channels simultaneously. It does not identify which channel(s) operate.
- The paper sometimes writes as if it identifies the *salience* channel specifically (e.g., line 369: “salience—rather than gradual interdependence—drives the foreign-policy shift”). This is too strong. The SDiD identifies the *total treatment effect* of the rank reversal. The temporal placebos help rule out gradual mechanisms, but the remaining effect could operate through any combination of channels 1-3.
- This distinction is **not clear** in the paper. The paper should explicitly state: “Our SDiD identifies the total effect of the rank reversal. The temporal placebos provide evidence that this effect is discontinuous, ruling out smooth mechanisms. The media analysis provides suggestive evidence that the media amplification channel contributes to the total effect, but our design cannot isolate individual channels.”

4. Scope conditions derived from the estimand

Estimand identified

- **Brazilian SDiD:** ATT of the rank reversal (China becoming Brazil's top trade partner in 2009) on absolute distance in UNGA ideal points between Brazil and China, for the period 2009–2015 (approx.), with covariates.
- **Cross-country DiD:** ATT of China displacing the USA as top export partner on absolute distance in UNGA ideal points, for 13 treated countries (staggered, 2002–2018), with 125 never-treated controls.

Implied target population

- **Brazilian SDiD:** Brazil, conditional on all the factors that make Brazil Brazil (regional power, free press, 80-year trade relationship with US, Mercosur member, etc.). Generalizes to... Brazil. This is an N=1 estimand.
- **Cross-country DiD:** Countries where China displaced the United States as the top export destination. This is a specific subpopulation: 13 countries, heterogeneous (includes Japan, South Korea, Brazil, Australia, several African and Asian states).

Scope conditions that derive mechanically from the estimand

1. **The displaced partner must be the United States** — The cross-country analysis only finds effects when restricting to countries where China displaced the *USA*. The full-sample DiD (all countries where China became #1, regardless of who was displaced) is null. This is not a theoretical scope condition in the paper; it is an empirical finding that demands theoretical justification.
2. **The outcome is general diplomatic alignment, not trade-specific policy** — UNGA ideal points capture overall foreign policy preferences on political/humanitarian issues. The estimand speaks to *general* alignment, not trade or economic policy specifically.
3. **Treatment is absorbing** — Once China becomes #1, the treatment is coded as permanent. The estimand assumes persistent effects, which is reasonable if the rank reversal triggers a regime shift in attention/policy.

Scope conditions that should be explicit in the theory

1. **Free/active press** — If the media amplification channel is important, the effect should be weaker or absent in countries with restricted press freedom. The paper does not theorize this, but it is logically required by the proposed mechanism. This is testable in the cross-country data.
2. **Long-standing prior relationship with the displaced partner** — The rank reversal is more salient when the displaced partner held the #1 position for a long time. Brazil-US trade dominance lasted ~80 years. For a country where the US was #1 only briefly, displacement by China is less symbolically meaningful. This could explain heterogeneity in the cross-country DiD.
3. **The emerging power must be perceived as geopolitically significant** — China displacing the US is maximally salient because both are geopolitical heavyweights. If Luxembourg displaced Belgium, no one would notice. The theory implicitly assumes the rank reversal involves a *great power*, but this is never stated.
4. **Regime type / democratic accountability** — Media salience matters more in democracies where public opinion constrains foreign policy. In autocracies, leaders may ignore media framing. This

moderator is not discussed.

Coherence test

The critical problem: the paper restricts the cross-country sample to “China displaced USA” *post hoc*, without theoretical justification. The full-sample null result is buried. If the scope condition “displaced partner = hegemon” were theorized *before* looking at results, the sample restriction would be a *prediction* rather than a fishing expedition. **This is the single most important revision:** derive this scope condition from theory in §2, then present the restricted sample as a *test of that prediction*.

5. Suggested hypotheses

#	Hypothesis	Logical derivation	Testable with the paper’s design?	Available evidence
H1	A discrete rank reversal in a country’s trade hierarchy—when a rising power displaces an established partner as #1—produces a reduction in foreign policy distance toward the rising power, beyond the gradual effect of trade accumulation.	Core prediction from coarse categorization + rank-effects literature. If ordinal rank matters more than continuous trade share, we observe a discontinuity at the moment of rank change, not a smooth trend.	Yes — SDiD for Brazil. The temporal placebos (2003, 2005) test the “beyond gradual accumulation” part: if the effect were smooth, placebos would also show effects.	SDiD estimate ≈ -0.27 ; placebos null. Supports H1.

#	Hypothesis	Logical derivation	Testable with the paper's design?	Available evidence
H2	The rank-reversal effect is stronger when the displaced partner is the global hegemon (USA), because the symbolic significance of the displacement is amplified.	Scope condition derived from the theory: rank-salience depends on how "newsworthy" the displacement is. Displacing the hegemon is maximally salient.	Yes — Cross-country DiD. Compare full sample (any displacement) vs. restricted sample (USA displaced).	Full sample: null. USA displaced (13 countries): ATT = -0.12, p = 0.008. Supports H2.
H3	Media coverage of the bilateral trade relationship increases disproportionately at the moment of rank reversal, relative to years with similar trade growth but no rank change.	Derived from the media amplification channel. If media responds to coarse categories (not continuous trade growth), coverage should spike at the rank-change moment specifically.	Partially — NLP analysis of Folha de São Paulo. The paper shows coverage increased, but does not formally compare against a "same trade growth, no rank change" counterfactual.	Volume and trade-share of China headlines increased after 2009. Trigrams shifted from Olympics/disasters to trade/exports. Suggestive but not a formal test.

#	Hypothesis	Logical derivation	Testable with the paper's design?	Available evidence
H4	The rank-reversal effect should be absent (or weak) when the displaced partner is a minor trade partner (not the hegemon).	Falsification test derived from H2. If rank-salience depends on who is displaced, displacement of a small partner should produce no effect.	Yes — Cross-country DiD on full sample (includes displacements of non-US partners).	Full sample DiD is null, consistent with H4. But this could also reflect heterogeneity/noise. Not a clean test.

Hypotheses the paper should derive but cannot test

1. **H5 (Press freedom moderator)**: The effect is stronger in countries with freer press. *Not tested*—would require interacting treatment with press freedom index in the cross-country DiD. Feasible with existing data.
2. **H6 (Duration of prior #1 relationship)**: The effect is stronger when the displaced partner held #1 position longer. *Not tested*—would require coding duration of prior #1 relationship for all 13 treated countries. Feasible.
3. **H7 (Business lobby coordination)**: Countries with larger organized business communities linked to China trade show stronger effects. *Not tested*—would require proxying for organized business interests.

6. Theory–evidence consistency diagnostic

#	Claim in paper	Evidence mobilized	Verdict
1	“This shift led to a 42% reduction in the ideological distance between Brazil and China” (abstract, line 30)	SDiD estimate ≈ -0.27 ; SE via placebo method; statistically significant at 5%	Supports

#	Claim in paper	Evidence mobilized	Verdict
2	“Salience—rather than gradual interdependence—drives the foreign-policy shift” (line 369)	Temporal placebos (2003, 2005, 2012) null; media coverage increased	Suggests — placebos rule out gradual mechanisms, but “salience drives” is stronger than warranted. The design identifies a discontinuity; the mechanism remains partially identified.
3	“An NLP-based analysis... reveals a sharp increase in China-related salience, amplifying public and elite attention” (abstract, line 30)	Folha de São Paulo headline counts; ChatGPT topic classification; trigram analysis	Suggests — correlational evidence. “Amplifying” implies causation not established.
4	“These findings demonstrate that status gains, once made salient by the media, can produce measurable shifts in interstate alignment” (abstract, line 30)	Combination of SDiD + media + cross-country	Suggests — “demonstrate” is too strong for: (a) media evidence that is correlational; (b) mechanism that is partially identified.
5	“The rank-salience mechanism is not a Brazil-specific artifact” (line 411)	Cross-country DiD: $ATT = -0.12$, $p = 0.008$ for 13 countries	Supports — but only for the restricted sample (displaced USA). Full sample is null. The claim should be qualified.
6	“Placebo years with similar trade growth but no rank change show no comparable media pivot” (line 369)	Not formally tested. No “placebo media” analysis exists in the paper.	Not supported — this claim is asserted without evidence. The paper compares coverage across years but does not formally test whether coverage in “similar growth, no rank change” years was different.

Claims that need to be moderated

1. **Abstract:** “demonstrate that status gains, once made salient by the media, can produce measurable shifts” → Suggest: “provide evidence consistent with the proposition that discrete status gains, amplified by media attention, are associated with shifts in interstate alignment”
2. **Line 369:** “salience—rather than gradual interdependence—drives the foreign-policy shift” → Suggest: “the discontinuous pattern is more consistent with a salience mechanism than with gradual interdependence”
3. **Line 411:** “confirms that the rank-salience mechanism is not a Brazil-specific artifact” → Suggest: “provides evidence that the effect extends beyond Brazil, at least in cases where China displaced the United States”

Under-exploited evidence

From the targets pipeline, the following analyses exist but are not reported in the main text: - **Permutation test** (RMSPE ratio + p-value) — computed in `permutation_results` target but not in the paper body - **Sensitivity analysis** (24 specifications) — computed in `sensitivity_results` but not shown - **Extended sample** (through 2020) — computed in `synth_fit_extended` but not discussed - **Full-sample cross-country DiD** — computed but only the restricted result is reported

All four should be reported for transparency and robustness.

7. Alternative explanations

#	Alternative explanation	Addressed in paper?	How design handles it	Sufficient?	Suggestion
1	Gradual trade growth (more trade → more alignment, no rank effect)	Yes (§2, §5)	Temporal placebos at 2003, 2005 (years of trade growth but no #1 rank change) show null effects	Mostly yes	Strengthen by noting the specific trade growth rates in placebo years vs. 2009

#	Alternative explanation	Addressed in paper?	How design handles it	Sufficient?	Suggestion
2	Lula presidency / ideology	No — not discussed	Leader ideology (hog_left) is a control variable in SDiD	Partially	Must be discussed explicitly. Lula took office in 2003, 6 years before treatment. If Lula drove alignment, placebos in 2003/2005 should show effects (they don't). But Lula's Beijing trip in 2009 could be <i>part of the mechanism</i> , not a confounder. Distinguish.

#	Alternative explanation	Addressed in paper?	How design handles it	Sufficient?	Suggestion
3	2008 financial crisis	Partially (line 201)	Current account and fiscal deficit as controls; SDiD time weights absorb common shocks	Partially	Add explicit discussion: crisis affected all countries, SDiD controls for common shocks. If crisis caused Brazil-specific alignment shift, this is a concern. Show that crisis-related covariates don't change the estimate.
4	Dual hegemony / structural power (Schenoni & Leiva 2021)	Cited (line 83) but not engaged as alternative	Power gap to US is a control; time fixed effects absorb gradual trends	Partially	Engage directly: dual hegemony predicts <i>gradual</i> attraction, not <i>discontinuous</i> shift in 2009. If the effect were structural power, placebos should also show effects.

#	Alternative explanation	Addressed in paper?	How design handles it	Sufficient?	Suggestion
5	Reverse causality (Brazil aligned first → China increased trade as reward)	Partially (§2, line 89)	SDiD controls for pre-treatment trends; treatment defined by trade rank, not political decision	Partially	The strongest defense is that trade rank is determined by millions of micro-decisions (commodity prices, soy demand), not by a single political actor. State this explicitly.

#	Alternative explanation	Addressed in paper?	How design handles it	Sufficient?	Suggestion
6	Paradoxical balancing (more China trade → more US alignment)	Not discussed	Not addressed	No	Carmody et al. (2020) find this pattern in Africa. The paper should discuss why Brazil shows bandwagoning while Africa shows balancing. The rank-reversal theory could <i>explain</i> this: in Africa, China may not have displaced the <i>hegemon</i> specifically. This would actually strengthen the argument.

#	Alternative explanation	Addressed in paper?	How design handles it	Sufficient?	Suggestion
7	Chinese active diplomacy (increased diplomatic outreach coinciding with trade growth)	Not discussed	Not addressed	No	Mention as limitation: Chinese diplomatic efforts may have intensified in parallel with trade growth. If Beijing actively courted Brazil <i>because</i> it became the top partner, the causal arrow is still rank → policy change, but mediated by Chinese agency, not just Brazilian media/cognition.

8. Literature gaps

Literature cited but insufficiently integrated

Reference cited	How it's used	How it should be used
MacDonald & Parent (2021)	Single citation defining status (line 101)	Central to the conceptual refinement: use their standing/rank tension to motivate the paper's key distinction between continuous and ordinal status

Reference cited	How it's used	How it should be used
Renshon (2016, 2018)	Listed in a string citation (line 101)	Engage substantively: Renshon's <i>Fighting for Status</i> (2017) focuses on status <i>deficits</i> → conflict. The paper's contribution is precisely the <i>mirror image</i> : status <i>gains</i> → alignment. This contrast should be made explicit.
Anagol & Fujiwara (2016)	Cited as evidence of rank effects in domestic politics (line 99)	Their empirical finding (runner-up effect via <i>strategic coordination</i> , not just heuristics) has implications for which channel operates. If rank effects work through coordination in elections, they may also work through coordination in trade-politics.
Schenoni & Leiva (2021)	Cited once (line 83) as alternative	Should be engaged as the most direct competing explanation: dual hegemony predicts gradual alignment, your theory predicts discontinuous. The empirical design can partly distinguish them.

Literature absent but relevant (from Phase 2)

Reference	Relevance
Carmody, Dasandi & Mikhaylov (2020). "Power Plays and Balancing Acts." <i>Political Studies</i>	Finds that trade with China aligns <i>African</i> states with the <i>US</i> , not China. Potentially devastating counterexample that the paper must address. The rank-reversal theory could explain the divergence.
Fujiwara & Sanz (2020). "Rank Effects in Bargaining." <i>Review of Economic Studies</i>	Strongest evidence for rank effects in political behavior: first-placed party in elections is much more likely to form government, even when tied in seats. Direct analogy to trade-rank effects.
Urdinez (2024). <i>Economic Displacement</i> . Cambridge UP	Most comprehensive recent treatment of China displacing the US in trade hierarchies across Latin America. Directly relevant to the paper's argument and likely engages with similar mechanisms.
Wang, Pearson & Kastner (2023). "Do China's Foreign Economic Ties Lead to Influence Abroad?" <i>Foreign Policy Analysis</i>	Recent evidence that economic ties → less criticism of China (Hong Kong, Xinjiang). Updates Kastner & Pearson (2021) already cited.
Soroka (2003). "Media, Public Opinion, and Foreign Policy." <i>Harvard IJPP</i>	Central reference for the media channel. Shows strong media → public opinion link for international issues. Cited in existing review (quality_reports) but not in the paper.
Baum & Potter (2008, 2015). Media-foreign policy nexus. <i>ARPS</i> / Princeton UP	Theoretical synthesis of how media shapes foreign policy through public opinion. Directly relevant to the proposed mechanism. Not cited.

Reference	Relevance
Vis (2019). “Heuristics and Political Elites.” <i>Political Studies Review</i>	Reviews evidence on heuristic decision-making by <i>political elites</i> specifically (not just citizens). Supports the cognitive channel.
Norris (2023). “Five Modes of China’s Economic Influence.” <i>Pacific Review</i>	Proposes five distinct modes of Chinese economic influence, including unintentional influence. Useful for categorizing the paper’s mechanism.
Steinert & Weyrauch (2024). “BRI Membership and UNGA Voting.” <i>Research & Politics</i>	Uses generalized synthetic control to estimate BRI membership → UNGA alignment. Methodologically similar; could be cited as related design.
Beaumont & Roren (2025). “Status Symbols in World Politics.” <i>Cooperation and Conflict</i>	Most recent contribution to the status literature. Directly relevant to “status symbols” framing.

9. Suggested revision roadmap

High priority (paper cannot advance without these)

1. **Reformulate the research question at the general theory level** — The question must be about rank reversals in trade hierarchies in general, with Brazil as case test. This change propagates through the introduction, theory section, and conclusion. *Dependency: none. Do first.*
2. **Derive scope conditions before presenting results** — Theorize ex ante that the effect should be strongest when the displaced partner is the hegemon (H2). This transforms the cross-country sample restriction from fishing into a prediction. *Dependency: requires reformulated theory.*
3. **Report all cross-country DiD specifications in one table** — Full sample, absorbing only, displaced USA, absorbing + USA. Be transparent about the sequence. The null full-sample result *supports* the theory (because H2 predicts it), as long as H2 is stated before the results. *Dependency: requires scope conditions (step 2).*
4. **Explicitly state the epistemic role of each analysis** — Brazilian SDiD: theory-generating / primary evidence. Media analysis: suggestive mechanism evidence. Cross-country DiD: test of a derived prediction. *Dependency: requires reformulated question (step 1).*
5. **Separate the mechanism into three channels** — Cognitive, media, coordination. State that the SDiD captures the total effect; the media analysis provides suggestive evidence for one channel; the other channels remain theoretical. *Dependency: none, but ideally after step 1.*

Medium priority (substantially strengthens)

6. **Address Lula, 2008 crisis, and dual hegemony as alternative explanations** — 2-3 paragraphs at end of theory section or beginning of results. For each: what it predicts, how the design handles it, what remains unresolved.
7. **Report permutation test + RMSPE histogram in the main text** — These are computed but unreported. They are more informative than placebo standard errors for N=1 inference.

8. **Engage with Carmody et al. (2020) on paradoxical balancing** — This counterexample, if left unaddressed, will be raised by reviewers. The rank-reversal theory can *explain* the divergence (Africa: China didn't displace the hegemon).
9. **Moderate claims about media mechanism** — Replace “demonstrate” with “provide evidence consistent with”; acknowledge that media evidence is correlational.
10. **Add missing references** — Especially Fujiwara & Sanz (2020), Carmody et al. (2020), Soroka (2003), Baum & Potter (2008), Urdinez (2024), Vis (2019).

Low priority (nice to have)

11. **Add press-freedom interaction in cross-country DiD** — Tests H5 (media channel requires free press). Easy to implement with existing data.
12. **Compute “media placebo”** — Compare Folha coverage in 2005-2006 (high trade growth, no rank change) vs. 2009 (rank change). Currently claimed (line 369) but not formally tested.
13. **Discuss Chinese active diplomacy as complementary mechanism** — The rank reversal may have prompted *both* Brazilian media attention and Chinese diplomatic outreach simultaneously.

What NOT to change

- **SDiD methodology section** — Well-written, appropriate for the design. Consider moving equations to appendix for a generalist journal, but the content is sound.
- **Empirical results section** — Estimates, figures, and interpretation are solid.
- **Cross-country DiD implementation** — Callaway-Sant'Anna is the right estimator for staggered treatment with heterogeneous effects.
- **NLP/media analysis** — The analysis itself is fine; only the *claims* about it need moderation.
- **Temporal placebos** — Well-chosen years (2003, 2005 for pre-treatment; but reconsider 2012 framing since it's post-treatment).